



Religious and Conservative College Students’ Perceptions on Prescription Stimulant Usage

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Supported by BYU-Idaho’s Office of Institutional Research FDSMR Grant and the Department of Psychology

INTRODUCTION

Research from Weyandt et al. (2009) finds that stimulant use without a prescription is fairly common and viewed as relatively safe among college students high in self-reported ADHD symptoms. Similarly, the present study seeks to investigate attitudes toward stimulant use without a prescription, but among a unique, religiously conservative, college student sample.

STUDY HYPOTHESES

- **Self-reported ADHD symptoms will be higher among those with prescriptions for stimulant use.**
- **Students will report attitudes reflecting a general acceptance for prescription stimulant use, similar to Weyandt et al (2009).**

METHODS

Participants

Participants included 1045 undergraduate students. The sample consisted of 59.8 % females and was 80.8% white.

Procedure

Three groups were compared in our analyses based on prescription status:

1. Those with a current prescription for stimulants to treat ADHD (CURRENT, n=41).
2. Those who do not currently have a prescription to treat ADHD, but have had one on the past (PRIOR, n=65).
3. Those who have never had a prescription to treat ADHD (NEVER, n=925).

Measures

- *Perceptions and Attitudes on Stimulant Use:* Students were asked to rate their perception of safety, knowledge of side effects, and knowledge of other students’ usage of prescription stimulants without a prescription (1 = Strongly Disagree, 7 = Strongly Agree), $\alpha = 0.84$ (Weyandt et al., 2009). Only 14 of the original items were used.
- *Internal Restlessness Scale (IRS):* Students were asked to rate themselves on a series of items about internal or mental restlessness (1=some of the time, 7=all of the time), $\alpha = 0.87$ (Weyandt et al., 2003)

RESULTS

Table 1. ANOVA tests on Internal Restlessness and prescription stimulant use.

ANOVA – Internal Restlessness Total Score					
Cases	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	p
Prescription Status	8272	2	4135.8	24.40	< .001
Residual	173899	1026	169.5		

Note. Type III Sum of Squares

Post Hoc Comparisons – Prescription Status						
		Mean Difference	SE	t	Cohen's d	p _{scheffe}
Current	Prior	7.821	2.596	3.012	0.485	0.011
	Never	13.211	2.078	6.358	1.030	< .001
Prior	Never	5.390	1.671	3.226	0.420	0.006

Figure 1. Mean self-report Internal Restlessness and prescription stimulant use.

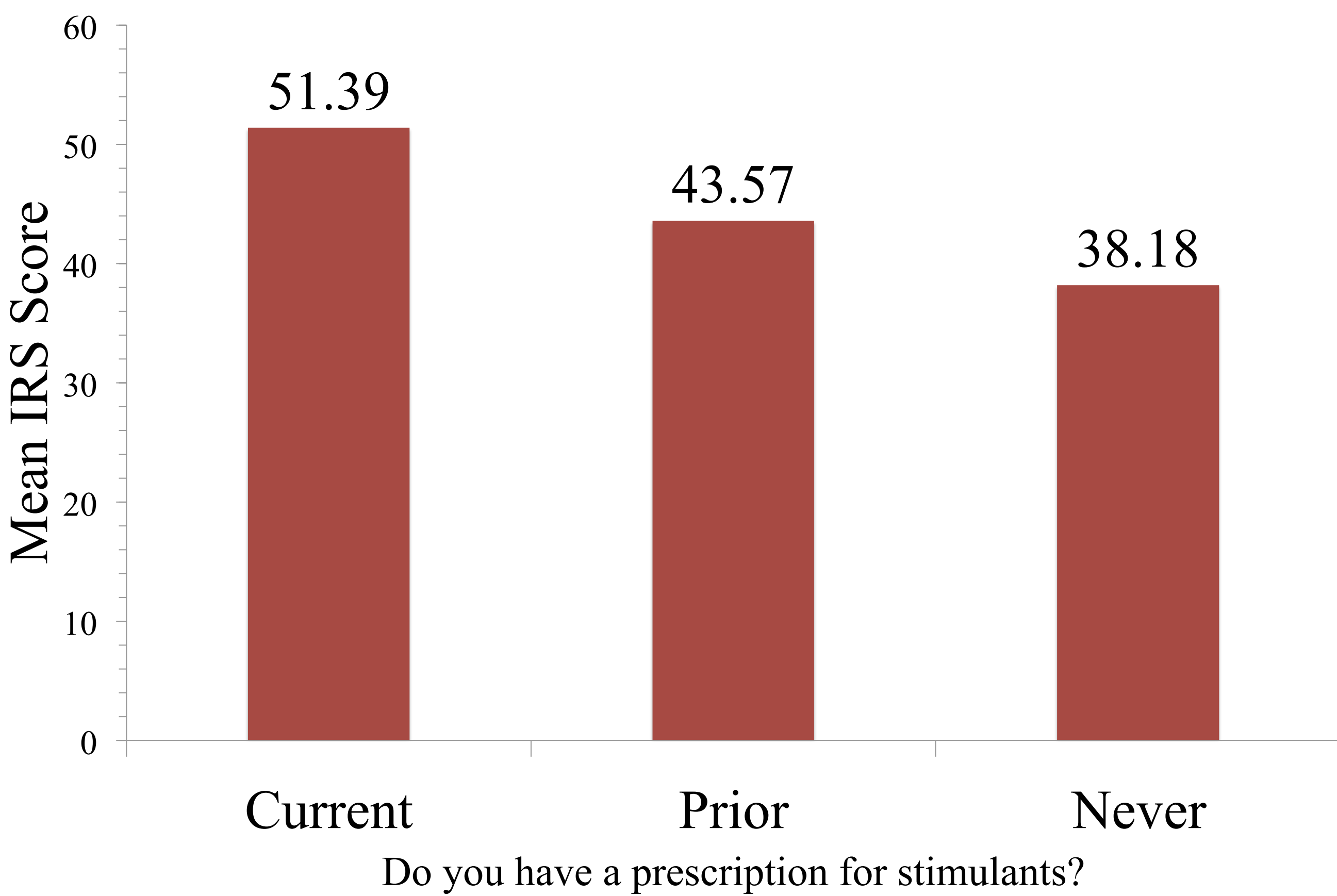


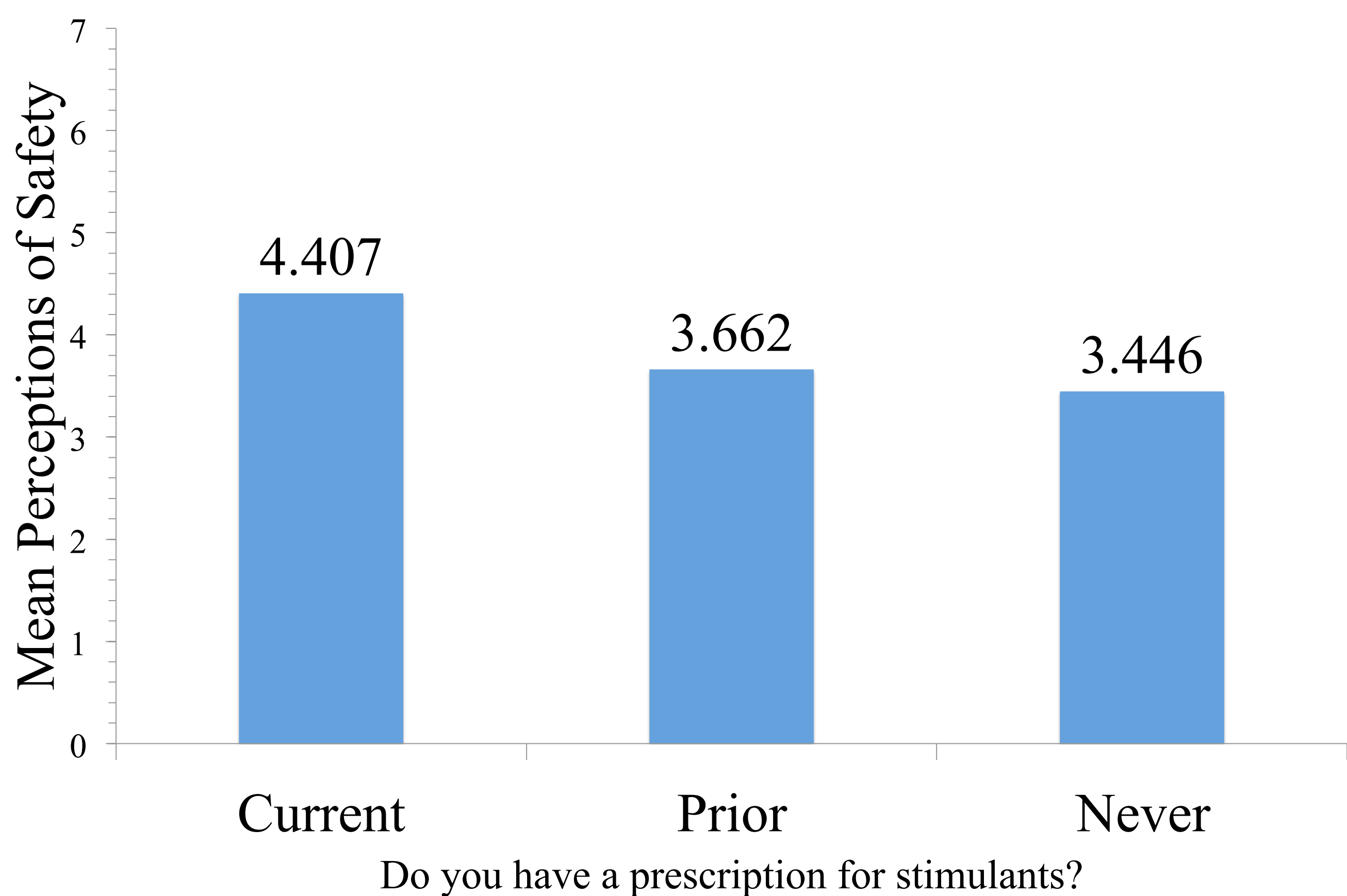
Table 2 . ANOVA tests on perception of safety and prescription stimulant use.

ANOVA – Perceptions of Safety					
Cases	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	p
Prescription Status	37.26	2	18.630	9.728	< .001
Residual	1905.50	995	1.915		

Note. Type III Sum of Squares

Post Hoc Comparisons – Prescription Status						
		Mean Difference	SE	t	Cohen's d	p _{scheffe}
Current	Prior	0.746	0.278	2.682	0.498	0.028
	Never	0.962	0.224	4.300	0.700	< .001
Prior	Never	0.216	0.178	1.213	0.156	0.479

Figure 2 . Mean self-report perception of safety and prescription stimulant use.



CONCLUSIONS

Findings support our first hypothesis, but results diverge from expectations about students’ perceptions of stimulant use. Weyandt et al. found generally favorable attitudes toward prescription stimulant use among all students, but we found two interesting differences from those findings: 1) higher IRS scores were associated with the CURRENT group and 2) students in our sample with no prescription viewed stimulants as less safe, perhaps owing to the conservative nature of our sample. It may be the lack of exposure to prescription stimulant use or conservative beliefs driving our results. Future research among other religiously conservative samples may help elucidate an explanation and determine whether this is a generalizable pattern or an artifact of our sample. This and similar findings may indicate that specific environmental factors associated with students’ campuses can positively affect their perceptions on prescription stimulant and other substance use.